Karachi gets you ready for Perth. You learn how to cut and pull, not just lug the ball around but defeat the pace and counter the bounce. Yes, the ball gets old quite soon. However, now that's all done away with, due to the introduction of turf.

With turf, especially with the new fail-safe kind they have in schools and clubs, there's barely any bounce above your knees. So the bloodline of hard-cutting, big-slashing batsmen in Karachi has thinned out. We don't make any Saeed Anwars anymore who can rip a cut shot to the last stand of the Melbourne Cricket Ground (MCG). No longer are we physically prepared to play in South Africa or Australia, with their hard and fast wickets. By upgrading to turf – which is cheaper to maintain – we have hurt our batting prospects. That's a part of my theory about our batting woes. Of course, for the larger oversights in Karachi and the loss of its great batting tradition, I blame the Pakistan Cricket Board.

This is how the infamous decline in our batting standards is connected to the loss of our prized national possession: the city of Karachi. In my theory, the cricket connection of this city by the sea, one of the world's largest megacities, is with cement. Maybe it's because Karachi is a concrete jungle.

Consider these men – Zaheer Abbas, Iqbal Qasim, Saeed Anwar, Asif Iqbal, Javed Miandad. I've followed their career through and through and have reached one conclusion. The main logistical and technical reason the Karachi boys rule the roost of Pakistani batsmen is because of the high bounce, no-nonsense cement pitches we grew up playing on.

It's also a mentality thing. Guys from Karachi are street-smart. They're mentally tough. They're probably more educated, statistically speaking, for that's the ethic in Karachi. That matters on the field, when you're cutting and pulling and slashing, be it in Perth or Brisbane. Compared to Karachi, Lahore is, well, more of a village, like the rest of the Punjab, while the north brings in the raw energy of the rural areas, which is why better bowlers have always emerged from there and from further north, like Khyber Pakhtunkhwa. It's in the water. And it's in the blood.

But let's be honest and not play the victim card. Karachiites lost Karachi. Nobody else can be held more responsible for nearly destroying Pakistan's biggest city than Karachiites themselves. We could have made it like New York or London, a real megacity. But an elder generation lost it for us.

So prevalent is crime in my town that no family in Karachi can claim it hasn't suffered an incident or some form of trauma. I'm one of those. I remember an episode from the mid-1990s when I was just starting out in cricket. I had borrowed a motorbike – a brand new Honda – from my brother for a match. I was near the crowded Ayesha Manzil, hungry, and pulled over to get something to eat from a *dhaba*. I went in, picked up a snack, came back out and saw two guys sitting on my bike as if it was their own.

I asked them to get off the bike, thinking they might have mistaken it for theirs. The guy on the pillion seat pulled out a shiny 9 mm pistol, pointed it at me and didn't say a word. The other guy, the soon-to-be driver, put out his empty palm. I knew what was expected of me. I gave them the key and backed away, slowly. I didn't want to be a hero in a bike robbery. Worse things have happened to better people on the streets of Karachi. This happened in 1995, just a year before my international debut.

The crime wave that started since hasn't stopped. Karachi has turned on to itself, like a crazed